ZikShare

ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

Note-Taking and Lecture Skills: Capture Ideas, Not Sentences

A practical note system for fast lecturers, crowded halls and heavy courses

STUDY SKILLS

Study Skills

General Studies (GST / CED)
GST Directorate | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

Free to download. No fee, no payment step, no watermark.

Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

Writing every word is impossible and unnecessary. This pack teaches structural note-taking, the Cornell layout, abbreviation systems and a post-lecture consolidation routine that turns messy notes into usable revision material.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Take structured notes that show relationships between ideas.
- Use the Cornell method and effective abbreviations under time pressure.
- Identify key points, examples and lecturer cues.
- Consolidate notes within a day so they remain useful.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Listen for structure

Lecturers signal importance. Learn the signals and you can take fewer, better notes.

- Cues: 'there are three types', 'the key point is', 'note this', 'in contrast'.
- Record headings and sub-points before details.
- Capture definitions, formulas, examples and the lecturer's emphasis.
- Leave space for gaps rather than guessing; mark them with a question symbol.
- Do not copy slides word for word if they will be shared; note what the lecturer adds.
- If you miss a point, write the heading and move on - keep following the argument.

The Cornell layout

It is popular because it separates recording from reviewing.

- Divide the page: a narrow cue column on the left, a wide notes column, and a summary strip at the bottom.
- During the lecture, write notes in the wide column.
- Within 24 hours, write keywords and questions in the cue column.
- Write a two-sentence summary at the bottom.
- Cover the notes column and use the cues to test yourself.
- The layout works on paper and in any notes app with a table.

> **Fewer words, more structure**
> A page of well-indented headings with six clear points is more useful than three pages of unreadable sentences.

Abbreviations and consolidation

Notes are for you, but they must still be readable a month later.

- Agree on abbreviations for your course: define them on the first page.
- Use symbols consistently: arrows for causation, therefore, versus and increase.
- Rewrite key ideas in your own words; this is where learning happens.
- Add one worked example per concept.
- Link today's notes to previous topics with references.
- Convert one page of notes into five flashcard questions each week.

A lecture is an argument, not dictation

Lecturers speak in structures even when they do not announce them. Common patterns: cause and effect, comparison, problem and solution, chronological development, and claim-evidence-conclusion. If you can hear the pattern in the first three minutes, your notes organise themselves.

Signals tell you what matters: "there are three reasons", "the important point is", "this contrasts with", "note that", "in the exam". Write those phrases down verbatim; they are the lecturer telling you what will be assessed.

You cannot write everything and you should not try. The aim is a usable record: enough to reconstruct the argument later, not a transcript. Students who transcribe lose the reasoning because their attention is on the words rather than the structure.

Systems that work

The Cornell layout divides a page into a wide notes column, a narrow cue column and a summary strip at the bottom. You write notes during the lecture, cues and questions afterwards, and a two-sentence summary at the end. The value is in the second pass, which forces retrieval.

For scientific and technical content, diagrams and worked examples matter more than prose. Copy the diagram, then label it from memory later. For humanities lectures, record the argument and the evidence offered for it, plus the strongest counter-argument mentioned.

Whatever the system, the notes must contain three things: what the topic is, the key claims with their support, and your own questions. A page with none of the third is a page you have not engaged with.

> **Review within 24 hours**
> Ten minutes of tidying and self-testing the day after a lecture is worth more than an hour of rereading it the week before examinations.

Listening, asking and recording

Active listening means predicting what comes next and checking whether you were right. When the lecturer gives an example, ask what general principle it illustrates. When a definition is given, ask what it excludes.

Ask questions in the moment if the lecture allows, otherwise write them and ask after the class or by email. A specific question gets a specific answer: "you said the policy failed because of implementation - was that funding or capacity?" is answerable; "I did not understand the policy part" is not.

If you record audio, ask permission, and never rely on the recording instead of notes. A recording you never revisit is a substitute for attention, not a support for it.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Cornell page for one lecture

Set up a page for a lecture titled "Sources of Nigerian law".

1. Top line: course code, date, lecturer, topic.
2. Notes column: the sources listed, with one line of explanation each.
3. Mark the lecturer's signal phrases where they appeared.
4. Cue column afterwards: "What is the hierarchy?", "What is the repugnancy test?", "Which source is supreme?"
5. Summary strip: two sentences stating the lecture's argument.
6. Transfer the unanswered cues to your questions list.

> **What to carry forward**
> The cues and summary are written after the lecture. That second pass is where learning happens.

2. Rescuing bad notes

Your notes from last week are unreadable fragments.

1. Do not copy them out as they are.
2. Get the lecture topic and outline from the course outline or a classmate.
3. Reconstruct the structure: what were the main sections?
4. Fill each section either from memory first, then from the textbook.
5. Mark the gaps you cannot fill and ask about them.
6. Adopt one note system immediately so this does not recur.

> **What to carry forward**
> Reconstruct from structure first, memory second, source third.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Explain why transcription is an ineffective note-taking strategy.

10 marks

1. Attention is on words rather than structure.
2. No processing occurs, so no encoding.
3. Transcripts are long and never reviewed.
4. Replacement: structured notes with cues and summary.

Q2. Describe the Cornell note-taking system and its purpose.

10 marks

1. Notes column during the lecture.
2. Cue column for questions afterwards.
3. Summary strip at the bottom.
4. Explain the retrieval value of the second pass.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Cornell notes. A page layout with notes, cue questions and a summary strip.

Signposting. Phrases a speaker uses to signal structure and importance.

Active listening. Listening with prediction and checking rather than passive reception.

Cue column. The narrow margin where questions and keywords are written after a lecture.

Transcript. A verbatim record of speech, distinct from structured notes.

Encoding. The process by which information enters long-term memory.

Retrieval. Bringing stored information back into awareness.

Course outline. The document listing topics and assessment for a course.

Concept map. A diagram linking concepts by labelled relationships.

Paraphrase. Restating content in your own words.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Structure

Hearing the pattern.

- Identify the structure of three lectures.
- Copy signal phrases verbatim.
- Set up Cornell pages.

Week 2 - System

Consistency.

- Use one system for every lecture.
- Complete cue columns the same day.
- Write summaries in two sentences.

Week 3 - Review

Retrieval.

- Self-test from cues for three lectures.
- Redraw one diagram from memory.
- Log unanswered questions.

Week 4 - Repair

Gaps.

- Reconstruct one bad set of notes.
- Ask two specific questions.
- Compare notes with a classmate.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- A study skills guide section on lecture note-taking.
- Your course outlines for topic structures.
- A guide to concept mapping for revision.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. What are the three sections of a Cornell notes page?

Answer: Cue column, notes column and summary section.

2. Why should you avoid transcribing a lecture word for word?

Answer: It prevents you from processing the argument and slows you down, so you miss connections and later points.

3. Give three lecturer cues that signal important content.

Answer: 'The key point is', 'there are three types' and 'note this'. Emphasis, repetition and diagrams also signal importance.

4. What should you do within 24 hours of a lecture?

Answer: Review and rewrite notes in your own words, fill gaps and write cue questions.

5. How do you handle a missed point during a fast lecture?

Answer: Mark the gap with a symbol, keep following the structure, and fill the gap afterwards from a textbook or a coursemate.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Set up one Cornell page for each of three courses.
- [ ] Define ten abbreviations for your most technical course.
- [ ] Attend two lectures using the structure-first method.
- [ ] Consolidate each set of notes within 24 hours for one week.
- [ ] Convert one lecture into five flashcard questions.
- [ ] Compare notes with a coursemate to check for gaps.
- [ ] Review a month-old note and identify what makes it hard to use.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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